

Australia Daily Brief

Tuesday, September 22, 2026

1,608 words · 6 min read

RE: US blasts Australia's digital duty of care bill · Marles wants Defence out of \$3bn sites · NZ warships transit Taiwan Strait · PIF leaders take priorities to UNGA81 · Peters calls Palestinian recognition 'inevitable'

ASX 200

8,758

+0.98%

AUD/USD

0.7120

-0.08%

NZX 50

13,875

+2.21%

NZD/USD

0.5748

-0.05%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Washington's embassy publicly branded Canberra's draft digital duty of care bill 'extraterritorial censorship' and demanded US platforms be exempted, an unusually blunt rebuke landing as Albanese promotes the same online safety model at the UN.
- 2 Pacific Islands Forum leaders carried priorities set at Palau's Leaders Meeting to UNGA81 in New York, with Solomon Islands' Matthew Wale separately pressing climate finance directly on the UN Secretary-General.
- 3 New Zealand naval vessels transited the Taiwan Strait as outgoing Foreign Minister Winston Peters used his valedictory remarks to call recognition of Palestinian statehood 'inevitable' and to defend the costs of the nuclear-free policy.

• TOP STORIES

AU-DEFENSE

Marles wants Defence out of \$3 billion sites 'as soon as possible'

Deputy Prime Minister **Richard Marles** said he wants Defence divested from \$3 *billion* worth of surplus sites as soon as possible, after the army admitted it mistakenly claimed it would remove all staff from one of the nation's most iconic defence sites by Christmas. The mixed messaging has renewed scrutiny of Defence's base consolidation plans.

per SMH Federal Politics (Matthew Knott): "Marles wants Defence out of \$3 billion sites 'as soon as possible'"

US-AUSTRALIA

US says Australian digital duty of care bill would 'facilitate censorship'

The Trump administration publicly criticized Australia's draft digital duty of care bill, calling for US social media companies to be excluded and warning the policy amounted to 'extraterritorial censorship of protected speech.' The submission, published by the US Embassy, said Washington has 'serious concerns' about how Australia would define 'foreseeable harm.' The rebuke lands as **Anthony Albanese** promotes Australian tech policy at the UN.

per ABC News: "US says Australian digital care bill would 'facilitate censorship'"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Pacific leaders take regional priorities to UNGA81

Pacific Islands Forum leaders travel to New York this week for the 81st UN General Assembly session to present priorities set at this month's 55th Leaders Meeting in Palau. The gathering follows Palau's **Surangel Whipps Jr.** assuming the Forum chair from Solomon Islands.

per Islands Business: "Pacific leaders take regional priorities to UNGA81" · also Pacific Island Times

• OVERNIGHT

AU-DEFENSE

[Former soldiers to face call-up obligations of ten years](#) · ABC Politics

New Australian Defence Force recruits will be required to remain available for call-up for *a decade* after leaving service, from October 1, doubling the previous five-year commitment period. The change follows a 2024 review that found Defence could ask more of departing personnel to grow its crisis reserve.

AU-DEFENSE

[Australia confirms F-35 jet parts went missing in Hong Kong](#) · ABC Politics

Canberra confirmed classified F-35 jet parts went missing in Hong Kong, prompting fresh concerns about Chinese security access to allied fighter technology. AFP separately reported an Australian minister described the missing parts as 'not sensitive.'

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[Albanese signs AI declaration with world leaders at the UN](#) · SMH Federal Politics

Anthony Albanese joined leaders including Canadian Prime Minister **Mark Carney** at the United Nations to declare that 'AI must remain under human direction, oversight and control.' The statement was signed alongside a slate of other world leaders during UN General Assembly week.

TRADE-ECONOMY

['Blood oil': Russian-origin fuel imports to Australia surge](#) · SMH Federal Politics

An analysis found the majority of fuel arriving in Australia from a major Asian refinery originated in Russia, raising questions about supply chains funding Moscow's war effort. The finding adds to scrutiny of Australia's indirect exposure to sanctioned Russian crude via third-country refining.

[NDIS minister warns Five Eyes allies of fraud risk to programs](#) · The Australian

Jenny McAllister briefed Five Eyes intelligence partners on fraud risks facing government support programs including the NDIS, The Australian reported. The disclosure points to growing coordination among the alliance on protecting public program integrity.

• STAT OF THE DAY

10 years

New ADF post-service call-up commitment, doubled from five years

From October 1, new Australian Defence Force recruits must remain available for call-up for a decade after leaving service, as Defence works to grow its reserve pool for a crisis.

ABC Politics

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 2 · ABC POLITICS

[US torpedo test-fired from UK sea drone for first time under AUKUS](#)

The United States test-fired a torpedo from a British uncrewed underwater vehicle for the first time under AUKUS arrangements, ABC reported. Further detail on the platform, location, and date was not provided in the initial report.

• PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · RNZ PACIFIC

[Bougainville independence vote awaits PNG parliament decision](#)

PNG's parliament is set to announce next month the date for its decision on ratifying Bougainville's 2019 independence referendum, in which *97.7 percent* voted for independence, RNZ Pacific reported. The result was tabled in parliament only last month, nearly seven years after the vote.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

[Wale presses climate finance case with UN Secretary-General](#)

Solomon Islands Prime Minister **Matthew Wale** called for greater climate finance and adaptation support for Pacific Island states in a meeting with the UN Secretary-General on the sidelines of UNGA81, Islands Business reported.

FIJI · FBC NEWS (FIJI)

[Fiji pushes stronger Pacific defence cooperation at Nadi meeting](#)

Opening the South Pacific Defence Ministers' Meeting in Nadi, Fiji's Defence Minister **Pio Tikoduadua** called for stronger regional cooperation and interoperability among Pacific neighbors to respond to an increasingly complex security environment.

FIJI · ABC PACIFIC

[Fijian civil groups fear constitutional review could delay elections](#)

Fijian civil society groups have raised concerns that the ongoing constitutional review process could delay the country's upcoming elections, ABC Pacific reported, as the review is expected to be presented to parliament.

KIRIBATI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Kiribati debates reviving ancestral name Tungaru

An I-Kiribati researcher has called for a national discussion on whether Kiribati should revert to its ancestral name, Tungaru, Islands Business reported, reviving a long-running decolonisation and identity debate.

TUVALU · ISLANDS BUSINESS (PACNEWS)

Tuvalu PM: traditional knowledge key to climate resilience

Tuvalu's prime minister said traditional knowledge is key to building climate resilience, according to the PACNEWS bulletin carried by Islands Business, part of wider Pacific reporting on climate adaptation ahead of PINA's journalist summit.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS (PACNEWS)

Fiji calls for climate finance to match Pacific needs

Fiji renewed calls for climate finance to match the scale of Pacific needs, according to the PACNEWS bulletin carried by Islands Business, ahead of Pacific journalists convening on ocean and climate reporting before the PINA summit.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Peters says NZ recognition of Palestinian statehood 'inevitable'

In his final speech as Foreign Affairs Minister, **Winston Peters** said New Zealand's 2025 decision not to join most UN member states in recognizing Palestine reflected 'truly independent foreign policy,' but recognition was a matter of 'when, not if.' He said he had recently spoken with the Palestinian Authority's foreign minister about plans to hold an election.

NZ-DEFENSE · AFP

Two New Zealand naval ships transit Taiwan Strait

Two New Zealand naval vessels transited the Taiwan Strait, AFP reported, without further detail on the ships involved or the timing of the passage in the initial dispatch.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Peters denies NZ First copied campaign group's health policy

Winston Peters rejected reporting that NZ First's 15-point 'Make New Zealand Healthy' plan closely mirrors a campaign group's website of the same name, calling the suggestion 'dumbo' and 'stupid.' Thirteen of the party's 15 points closely track the group's listed solutions.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

NZ supermarket duopoly becomes an election issue

New Zealand's two main supermarket chains hold *82 percent* of the grocery market, prompting parties to propose remedies from government-run supermarkets to breaking up Foodstuffs. The Commerce Commission found Foodstuffs North and South Islands post EBIT margins exceeding six percent, among the highest in its global comparison.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Joyce says Liberals, One Nation discussing confidence and supply pact

Barnaby Joyce said the Liberal Party and One Nation are discussing a confidence and supply arrangement, The Australian reported, a potential realignment that would reshape Coalition politics ahead of the next election.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Newspoll: two-thirds of Australians want fewer immigrants

A Newspoll survey found *two-thirds* of Australians support cutting immigration numbers, The Australian reported, intensifying pressure on the Albanese government's migration settings.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Exclusive Brethren leader swings support behind One Nation

The Exclusive Brethren's leader praised **Pauline Hanson** and urged Australia to use its uranium to 'build a few bombs,' SMH reported, as the secretive group that funded Coalition campaigns swings behind One Nation.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · SMH

RBA warns higher interest rates could be the new normal

Reserve Bank governor **Michele Bullock** warned rate cuts remain a long way off, with markets and major banks expecting another hike next week. The RBA held its cash rate at 4.35 percent on August 11, a second consecutive hold after three increases earlier in 2026.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

RBNZ warns near-term inflation may beat estimates as oil surges

New Zealand's central bank chief warned near-term inflation could exceed estimates as oil prices surge, Bloomberg reported, complicating the outlook for the Reserve Bank of New Zealand's policy path.

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

Carbon-credit land rush hollows out New Zealand farm country

A rush to convert New Zealand farmland into carbon-credit forestry is reshaping rural communities, Reuters reported, intensifying a land-use divide reflected in the country's election-year agriculture debates.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · AU MINISTERIAL

Australia names new High Commissioner to Papua New Guinea

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** announced a new Australian High Commissioner to Papua New Guinea, according to a media release from her office. No further detail on the appointee was included in the release summary provided.

COMMUNIQUE · PIF COMMUNIQUES

Pacific leaders call for Antarctic krill protection

Pacific leaders issued a call for stronger protections for Antarctic krill stocks, according to Matangi Tonga's report on the Forum's communique, linking Southern Ocean fisheries management to regional food security.

READOUT · AU MINISTERIAL

Australia launches bid for UN Security Council seat

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** launched Australia's bid for a seat on the UN Security Council, according to a media release from her office. The announcement coincides with UN General Assembly week in New York.

• UPCOMING

SEP
2026

RBA widely expected to raise the cash rate

Governor Bullock's remarks that rate cuts are 'a long way off' signal an end to the two-hold pause and a possible rise at the next board meeting.

OCT
20

India-New Zealand free trade pact enters into force

Marks a concrete step in New Zealand's trade diversification push after ratification of the agreement.

OCT
2026

PNG parliament to set date for Bougainville independence ratification decision

Sets the timeline for parliament to act on Bougainville's 2019 independence referendum, seven years after the vote.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition, and its foreign and defence policy settings under Peters and Collins, continues.

• THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Labor nears scrapping third-year backpacker visa, PALM implications loom

Devpolicy's **Stephen Howes** writes that Labor has all but scrapped the third-year backpacker visa, a change with direct implications for the Pacific Australia Labour Mobility scheme and farm sector reliance on it.

NZ-DEFENSE

AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

Australia and New Zealand fortify naval partnership

Australian Defence Magazine reported that Australia and New Zealand are deepening naval cooperation, without further detail provided in the item's summary.

• ANALYSIS AND OPINION

THE DIPLOMAT

Busting the Myths of the US Military's Presence in Hawai'i

As land leases underpinning the US military's footprint in Hawai'i come up for renewal, a new report examines the actual scope of the Armed Forces' presence and its impact on the islands. The piece situates Hawai'i's basing debate within the wider question of American force posture across the Pacific Islands.

Argument: A new report challenges assumptions about the scale and impact of the US Armed Forces' presence in Hawai'i as key land leases face renewal.

THE SPINOFF

Not without costs: Winston Peters questions nuclear-free 'mythologising'

In remarks tied to his valedictory address as Foreign Minister, **Winston Peters** questioned the mythologising of New Zealand's nuclear-free policy, saying costs did occur as a result of the stance. The commentary reopens a long-running debate over the foreign and defence policy trade-offs of the 1980s nuclear-free legislation.

Argument: Outgoing Foreign Minister Winston Peters argues New Zealand's nuclear-free stance carried real costs that are often mythologised rather than examined.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

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